

Morphology and Syntax (ENG509)

What is Morphology?

Morphology is the study of the internal structure of words and how they are formed from smaller units like roots, prefixes, and suffixes.

Example: "unhappiness" can be broken down into its morphological components: "un-" (prefix) + "happi-" (root) + "-ness" (suffix).

 **Words and Lexemes:** A word is a unit of language with a specific meaning, while a lexeme is the base form of a word without inflections.

Morphology and Phonology

Morphology deals with the structure of words, while phonology focuses on the sound system of language.

Example: "bat" and "hat" differ phonologically (sound), but are similar morphologically (structure).

Derivation and the Lexicon

Derivation involves adding affixes to roots to form new words, which are stored in the mental lexicon.

Example: "happy" (root) + "-ness" (suffix) = "happiness" (derived word).

Words & Forms: Inflections

Inflections are morphological changes that indicate grammatical function, like tense or number.

Example: "walk" (base form) vs. "walked" (inflected form).

Words & Its Relatives: Derivation

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Derivation creates new words by adding affixes, like -ed or -ness, to roots.

Example: "create" (root) + "-ion" (suffix) = "creation" (derived word).

Morphological Structures

Morphological structures include roots, prefixes, and suffixes that combine to form words.

Example: "un-" (prefix) + "break-" (root) + "-able" (suffix) = "unbreakable".

Derivation and Semantics

Derivation can change the meaning of a word, like adding -ful to create an adjective.

Example: "hope" (root) + "-ful" (suffix) = "hopeful" (derived adjective).

Inflections

Inflections are morphological changes that indicate grammatical function, like tense or number.

Example: "go" (base form) vs. "went" (inflected form).

Lexical Source of English Word Formation

English words can come from various sources, including Latin, Greek, and Germanic roots.

Example: "captain" comes from Latin "capitaneus".

Morphological Productivity and the Mental Lexicon

The mental lexicon stores words and their morphological structures, allowing for productive word formation.

Example: "un-" (prefix) + "happi-" (root) + "-ness" (suffix) = "unhappiness" (productively formed word).

Morphology and Syntax

Morphology studies word structure, while syntax examines how words combine to form sentences.

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Example: "The dog chased the cat." (syntax) vs. "dog" (morphology).

Morphology and Psycholinguistics

Morphology is related to psycholinguistics, as it involves the mental representation and processing of words.

Example: How we process and store morphological information in our mental lexicon.

Morphology and Language Change

Morphological structures can change over time, influencing language evolution.

Example: Old English "hwaet" (root) + "-er" (suffix) = "whater" (derived word), which became Modern English "water".

Traditional Grammar: Categories & Functions

Traditional grammar categorizes words into parts of speech based on their functions. The main categories are:

- **Nouns (N):** words that refer to people, places, things, or ideas (e.g., "dog", "city", "happiness")
- **Verbs (V):** words that express actions, events, or states (e.g., "run", "eat", "be")
- **Adjectives (Adj):** words that modify nouns or pronouns (e.g., "happy", "big", "blue")
- **Adverbs (Adv):** words that modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs (e.g., "quickly", "very", "well")
- **Pronouns (Pron):** words that replace nouns in a sentence (e.g., "he", "she", "it")
- **Prepositions (Prep):** words that show relationships between words in a sentence (e.g., "in", "on", "under")
- **Conjunctions (Conj):** words that connect words, phrases, or clauses (e.g., "and", "but", "or")
- **Interjections (Int):** words that express emotion or feeling (e.g., "oh", "ouch", "wow")

What is Syntax?

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Syntax is the study of how words are combined to form phrases, clauses, and sentences. It examines the rules and patterns that govern the structure of language.

Example: "The dog chased the cat."

- "The dog" is a noun phrase (NP) functioning as the subject.
- "chased" is a verb (V) functioning as the predicate.
- "the cat" is a noun phrase (NP) functioning as the object.

Universal Grammar

Universal Grammar (UG) is a theoretical framework that proposes all humans are born with an innate capacity for language, including a set of universal principles and constraints that shape language acquisition and use.

Example: All languages have a subject-verb-object word order, despite differences in language-specific grammar rules.

Sentence Presenting Constituency Tests

Constituency tests are used to identify the constituent structure of a sentence, which reveals how words group together to form phrases and clauses.

Example: "The man in the corner is reading a book."

- "The man in the corner" is a noun phrase (NP) functioning as the subject.
- "is reading" is a verb phrase (VP) functioning as the predicate.
- "a book" is a noun phrase (NP) functioning as the object.

Constituents: Words Order

Words can be ordered in different ways to form phrases and sentences.

Example: "The dog bit the man." vs. "The man was bitten by the dog."

Both sentences have the same words, but the word order changes the sentence structure and meaning.

Constituents: Phrases

Phrases are groups of words that function together as a unit.

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Example: "The big red car" is a noun phrase (NP) consisting of an article ("The"), an adjective ("big"), another adjective ("red"), and a noun ("car").

Content words and Function words

Content words carry meaning, while function words indicate grammatical relationships.

Example: "The dog ran quickly."

- "dog" is a content word (noun) carrying meaning.
- "The" is a function word (article) indicating the noun's grammatical function.
- "ran" is a content word (verb) carrying meaning.
- "quickly" is a function word (adverb) modifying the verb.

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